

Financially Sovereign Academy

Correctional and Reentry Program

Budgeting & Emergency Savings

Student Workbook

Version 0.1 (provisional) · 2026-07-04

Provisional pilot-ready draft. External counsel review pending. Not for final facility distribution until legal/privacy feedback is reconciled.

Described as pilot-ready, never proven or validated. No outcome or recidivism claims.
Not legally approved. Source & Claims Ledger held at v0.2.

Workbook Draft: Session 1, Where the Money Goes (v0.2)

Program: Budgeting & Emergency Savings (Correctional and Reentry) | File version: v0.2 (Session 1 content, post-audit) | Date: 2026-07-02 | Status: Needs Dalia review
Supersedes v0.1 (kept as history). Applies all 10 approved audit fixes + the session-timing fix + spine alignment on page 8 (D-12). Content only per D-11. All dollar amounts illustrative. Module spine (guides every page, never printed as jargon): when money is short, slow the damage, protect the next step, ask early, keep one option open.

Page 1: Welcome to Session 1, Where the Money Goes

Learner-facing text:

This class is about one thing: deciding where your money goes when there is not enough of it.

That is not a small skill. It is the skill.

A few ground rules for this workbook:

- Your worksheets are yours. Nobody collects them. Nobody reads them unless you choose to share.
- You can pass on any share-out. Writing it down is enough.
- There are no grades. Money has been hard for most of us at some point. This class is about what to do next.
- Some pages have no perfect answer. When that happens, the goal is to pick the choice that does the least damage, and to make the first call early. You will see this idea again.
- If you are still inside: use your best guesses. If you are out: use your real numbers. The pages work either way.

Activity instructions: none. Read together or alone.

Facilitator note (clarity): Read the “no perfect answer” line out loud before starting. It matters later in the session: when a learner hits a page where nothing fits, that line is what keeps it from feeling like personal failure.

Source-needed note: none.

Page 2: The First Week (pick your card)

Learner-facing text:

Marcus gets out on a Tuesday. Everything he has fits in one envelope.

Marcus’s story starts the week. The numbers you write are yours.

How much is in the envelope? That depends on the state, the family, and luck. So this activity gives you two cards. Pick the one closer to your reality.

CARD A: \$200. Release money plus some help from family. (*Example amount, not a real figure.*)

CARD B: \$60. Release money only. No family help coming. (*Example amount, not a real figure.*)

My real number: \$_____. If your number is different from both cards, use yours. The cards just start the story.

The week ahead needs some of these things. Prices are blank because they are different everywhere. Fill in your best guess:

What week one may need	My guess
Phone minutes (so a job can call back)	\$_____
Bus fare (check-ins, job search)	\$_____
Food for the week	\$_____
Clothes that feel like you again	\$_____
Something I know I will need that is not on this list: _____	\$_____

Activity instructions: Circle your card (A or B), or write your own number. Fill in your guesses. Do not solve anything yet. That is the next page.

Facilitator note (safety): Never ask who picked which card, and never ask anyone to say their amounts out loud. If someone says “I would not even have \$60,” take it seriously and say the truth: some people leave with less, which is exactly why this page uses cards instead of one number. That learner uses the “my real number” line.

Facilitator note (clarity): If someone stalls on a price guess because they have not bought anything in years, offer wide ranges out loud and say prices vary a lot by place. Do not write prices on the board; the guess is theirs.

Source-needed note: Actual release-money (“gate money”) amounts vary widely by state and are not printed here. If any real figure is ever added, it needs a dated, state-tagged source.

Page 3: The Week One Money Map (S01)

Learner-facing text:

Now make the money decide. One line at a time. No math tricks, just subtraction, one box per step.

My amount: \$_____

Step	What I am paying for	Cost	Money left after
1	_____	\$_____	\$_____
2	_____	\$_____	\$_____

Step	What I am paying for	Cost	Money left after
3	_____	\$ _____	\$ _____
4	_____	\$ _____	\$ _____
5	_____	\$ _____	\$ _____

The order is the decision. What you write on line 1 is what you are protecting most.

If you have Card B and it does not all fit: that is not a mistake in your math. That is the real situation. Do this instead:

1. Protect first: a place to sleep, food, staying legal (check-ins), and the thing that gets you paid.
2. For every line that did not fit, write one free or cheaper move next to it. Examples: food pantry instead of groceries once, ask about a phone plan for the smallest amount, clothes from a community closet this week and better ones later.
3. Nobody covers everything on \$60. The win is knowing your order and your backup moves before the week starts.

Activity instructions: Fill the map top to bottom. Then compare orders with a partner if you want to. Different orders are allowed; be ready to say why yours is yours.

Reflection prompt: What did you put on line 1, and what does that say about what you are protecting?

Facilitator note (safety): Pair sharing is optional, always. If the room is comparing, steer the talk to the order, never the amounts.

Source-needed note: Free-resource examples (food pantry, community closet) are generic on purpose. A local-resource insert sheet is a separate, per-facility item.

Page 4: What People Weigh on This Page (S01 answer guidance)

Learner-facing text:

There is no single right map. Here is what people who have done this week tend to weigh:

- **The thing that gets you paid comes early.** If the phone is how a job reaches you, a dead phone is expensive even though it looks cheap to skip.
- **Staying legal is not optional.** Missing a check-in to save bus fare costs more than bus fare.
- **Dignity is real.** Wanting clothes that fit who you are now is not weakness. The question is only when: some of it this week, or better once money steadies.
- **Whatever you skipped, name its backup.** A skipped line with a backup plan is a decision. A skipped line with nothing is a surprise waiting.

Activity instructions: Look back at your map once. Change it if you want. Changing your mind on paper is free. That is the point of paper.

Facilitator note (clarity): Run this page as a read-aloud while learners revise their maps. It keeps the 30-minute block on time and reaches learners who read slowly.

Source-needed note: none.

Page 5: Four Needs, One Twenty (S02, the setup)

Learner-facing text:

Denise has \$120 left and four things pulling on it.

1. **Phone bill, \$55.** Two jobs said “we will call you.”
2. **Bus pass, \$40.** Her check-in is Thursday. Missing it is not an option. She also needs to get to interviews.
3. **Groceries, about \$45.** The kitchen is nearly empty.
4. **State ID, \$30.** Jobs and everything else keep asking for it.

(All amounts are examples, not real prices.)

Then she finds out the catch: to get the state ID, the office wants her birth certificate. She does not have it. Ordering one takes time and its own small fee.

So this is not really “pick what to pay.” Some moves cannot even start yet. Some cannot wait. This is a puzzle about **order**.

Activity instructions: Cut or tear the four cards below (or just number them). Then go to the next page and place each one.

[CARD: PHONE \$55] [CARD: BUS PASS \$40] [CARD: GROCERIES \$45] [CARD: STATE ID \$30]

Facilitator note (clarity): If learners argue that ID should come first, do not correct them; ask “can she actually get the ID this week?” Let the birth-certificate catch do the teaching.

Source-needed note: ID and birth-certificate fees and requirements vary by state. Amounts here are examples. Any real figure needs a dated, state-tagged source; fee-waiver programs exist in some places and belong on the local-resource insert.

Page 6: This Week’s Order of Moves (S02 worksheet)

Learner-facing text:

Place each card in one box. A card can also split: part now, part later.

Box	What goes here	My cards
Starts today	The move that cannot wait or that starts a clock (like ordering the birth certificate)	
This week	Needs to happen before Sunday	
Waiting on something	Cannot happen yet; write what it is waiting for	
Partial or free move	A smaller or no-cost version (pantry, plan downgrade, fee-waiver question)	

Check your total: the “starts today” + “this week” cards cannot add up to more than \$120. One-step math: add two numbers at a time.

AFTER you finish. One version. Not the answer.

Denise’s week can look like this: bus pass today (Thursday is fixed), order the birth certificate today (it starts the ID clock and costs the least), groceries partly this week plus a pantry visit, phone this week because two jobs are about to call, full ID when the birth certificate arrives. Yours can be different. What matters is that every card has a box and every “waiting” card names what it waits for.

Activity instructions: Fill your boxes first. The bottom box is for after, not before.

Reflection prompt: Which of your own real-life moves is actually a “starts today” card that has been sitting in “someday”?

Facilitator note: none needed beyond page 5’s.

Source-needed note: covered on page 5.

Page 7: The Shock (session closer drill)

Learner-facing text:

Your map from page 3 was working. Then real life deals a card.

SHOCK CARD 1: The \$60 problem. Something breaks, or a ride falls through and paid transport is the only way to keep something you cannot lose. It costs about \$60. (*Example amount.*)

SHOCK CARD 2: The prescription. You need a medication refill now, and the coverage that would pay for it has not started yet. (*Support programs for this exist in many places; the point of the card is the timing gap, not the price.*)

Pick one card. Go back to your page 3 map and answer in the boxes below:

Question	My answer
What moves to make room?	
What must NOT move, no matter what?	
What free or cheaper backup could absorb part of this?	
Who could I tell early, before it becomes a bigger problem?	

If nothing on your map can move: that happens, especially on Card B. Then the last two boxes ARE your plan. A backup move plus an early call is a real answer.

Activity instructions: Ten minutes, alone, pencil on paper. Then the group talks about one question only: what must not move, and why.

Facilitator note (safety): This drill can land hard on someone currently living a shock. Say before starting: “This is practice on paper so the real one hurts less. If today IS the shock, do the page for your real situation or just listen; both count.” Keep the group discussion on the must-not-move question; do not let it become sharing amounts or medical details.

Facilitator note (boundary): If the medication card raises benefits questions (when coverage starts, how to enroll), do not answer from memory; rules differ by state and program. Route it: “Good question for the reentry office / case manager; write it down as your ask-early move.”

Source-needed note: Medication card wording stays generic by design. Benefits-reactivation timing varies by state and program; any specific claim needs a dated, state-tagged source. Prescription assistance programs belong on the local-resource insert.

Page 8: Before You Go (reflection + action step)

Learner-facing text:

One session, four ideas:

1. The order is the decision.
2. Some weeks nothing fits. Least damage plus an early call beats silence every time.
3. A shock hurts less when the map already exists.
4. A backup move is money you did not have to spend. Keeping one option open is the whole game.

My one reflection: The decision from today I most want to get right in real life is:

My action step (pick your track):

- **If you are still inside:** finish your week-one money map in estimates. Keep it with your release papers.

- **If you are out:** this week, walk your real numbers through the page 3 map once, and do the one “starts today” move from page 6, even if it is small.

Activity instructions: Write the reflection and circle your track before leaving. Thirty seconds. Done is the standard, not perfect.

Facilitator note: none needed.

Source-needed note: none.

Workbook Draft: Session 2, Plan to the Floor (v0.2)

Program: Budgeting & Emergency Savings (Correctional and Reentry) | Version: v0.2 (Session 2 content, post-audit) | Date: 2026-07-02 | Status: Needs Dalia review Supersedes v0.1 (kept as history). Applies all approved audit fixes. Spine: slow the damage, protect the next step, ask early, keep one option open. All dollar amounts illustrative. Standalone-safe.

Page 1: Welcome to Session 2, Plan to the Floor

Learner-facing text:

Last time (or if this is your first class, here it is in one line): when money is short, the order you pay things in is the decision.

Today is about a harder problem: money that will not hold still. Paychecks that change size. A job that starts later than the bills do. This session teaches one rule that makes unstable money plannable:

Plan to your worst week, not your average week. We call that worst week your floor.

Ground rules, same as every session: your worksheets are yours, you can pass on any share-out, and some pages have no perfect answer. When that happens, pick the least damage and make the first call early. And one more: **if you are still inside, use your best guesses; if you are out, use your real numbers. The pages work either way.**

Activity instructions: none. Read together.

Facilitator note (clarity): If some learners were not in Session 1, the first paragraph is their catch-up. Do not re-teach; the pages carry it.

Source-needed note: none.

Page 2: Job Starts on the 15th (S03, the setup)

Learner-facing text:

Andre got the call: he is hired. Orientation is in 12 days. The first paycheck comes about three weeks after that.

Good news with a math problem inside it: the bills do not wait for orientation.

Pick the row that matches your situation. Both use the same worksheet.

- **Track A: Household.** Andre owes \$200 to the household on the 1st. It is family. It might be negotiable. Asking feels heavy.

- **Track B: Program housing.** Andre owes a \$200 program fee on the 1st. The amount is fixed. The timing might not be. There is no one to bargain with, but there may be someone to ask.

Then his cousin offers help: “I got you. Pay me back first, though. Before your rent, before anything. Family remembers.”

(All amounts are examples.)

The decision: how does Andre cross the gap between today and the first paycheck without paying for it twice?

Activity instructions: Circle your track. Then build the timeline on the next page.

Facilitator note (safety): Never ask who circled which track; housing situations are private. If someone asks which track is “worse,” the honest answer is neither: A costs a hard conversation, B costs creativity.

Source-needed note: Transitional-housing fee structures vary by program and state. One-time assistance funds and food support exist in many places; specifics belong on the local-resource insert, not this page.

Page 3: The Gap Timeline (S03 worksheet)

Learner-facing text:

Draw the gap before it draws on you. One box per line, no tricky math.

When	What happens	Money in	Money owed
Today		\$_____	
The 1st	Rent / program fee due		\$200
Day 12	Orientation (unpaid)		
About day 33	First paycheck	\$_____	

Now the bridge. Write one move in each box that fits your track:

Bridge move	Track A (household)	Track B (fixed fee)
The early conversation	Who do I talk to before the 1st, and what exactly do I say?	Is there an office that can align the fee date with my pay date? What is the question, in writing?
The free or cheaper move		
The one-time help move (assistance fund, food support)		

Bridge move	Track A (household)	Track B (fixed fee)
What I will NOT do		

About the cousin's offer. Before reading on, answer one question for yourself: **what is the real price of this offer?**

Write it: _____

The price is not interest. The price is the repayment order and the relationship. "Pay me back first, before rent" becomes a new bill with your name on it, ahead of the ones that keep you housed.

If you are on Track B and nothing bends: that happens. Then least damage looks like this: protect the fee that protects your housing, bridge food and transport with free moves, and make the early ask anyway, because "I start work on the 15th and my first check lands about the 3rd" is information an office can sometimes work with. Asking early is not weakness. It is the cheapest move on this page.

AFTER you finish. One version. Not the answer.

Track A people often land on: tell the household before the 1st, offer a specific date and a specific amount ("full \$200 on the 5th, or \$80 now and the rest on the 5th"), and keep the promise small enough to keep. Track B people often land on: ask the office one written question about timing, take the food support without shame. Many people only take an offer like the cousin's if the terms go on paper, so the friendship and the debt stay two different things.

Activity instructions: Fill the timeline, then the bridge boxes for your track. Pairs optional: compare bridge moves, not amounts.

Reflection prompt: Which costs you more this month: the hard conversation, or avoiding it?

Facilitator note (boundary): If a learner asks whether a program fee can legally do X, do not answer; route it: "Ask the program office, in writing, and keep the copy."

Source-needed note: none beyond page 2's.

Page 4: Three Paychecks, Three Sizes (\$13, the grid)

Learner-facing text:

Rosa works at a restaurant. Hours move around, so pay moves around. Three weeks, three paychecks:

Week 1: \$310. Week 2: \$180. Week 3: \$260. (*Examples.*)

Her fixed weekly costs are printed below. Work one row at a time, one subtraction per box. Left to right, no skipping.

	Money in	minus housing share \$100	minus phone \$20	minus transit \$40	Left over
Week 1	\$310	\$ _____	\$ _____	\$ _____	\$ _____
Week 2	\$180	\$ _____	\$ _____	\$ _____	\$ _____
Week 3	\$260	\$ _____	\$ _____	\$ _____	\$ _____

Now circle the smallest “left over” number.

That circle is your **floor**. Food and everything else live inside the floor. A plan built on the \$310 week dies in the \$180 week. A plan built on the floor survives all three.

Activity instructions: One subtraction per box. Check with a partner if you want; the boxes make it easy to spot a slip. Then circle the floor.

Facilitator note (clarity): If the room includes very low numeracy, do week 1 together on the board as the worked row, then let weeks 2 and 3 be individual. All numbers are round tens on purpose.

Source-needed note: All figures illustrative. If this grid ever uses real local costs, each needs a dated source or an “example” label, per the claim rules.

Page 5: What the Floor Buys You (S13 guidance)

Learner-facing text:

Rosa’s floor week leaves \$20 after the fixed bills. (*If your boxes said \$20, your math is right.*)

That sounds like bad news. It is actually the most useful number on the page:

- **The floor is your truth number.** Any plan that needs more than the floor is a hope, not a plan.
- **Food gets planned at the floor, stretched in bad weeks, upgraded in good ones.** Not the other way around.
- **Good weeks are not raises. They are supplies.** Week 1 was \$130 above the floor. That difference is what the next page is about.
- **Some real weeks go below zero.** That is not a floor problem, that is a gap problem, and you already built the tool for it: the early ask and the bridge moves from page 3.

Activity instructions: Read-aloud page while learners check their circles.

Reflection prompt: What is your floor, roughly? You do not have to share it. Just know it.

Facilitator note (clarity): Run as read-aloud (timing pattern from Session 1). Keep amounts private; the reflection is for their page, not the room.

Source-needed note: none.

Page 6: The Good Week (S14)

Learner-facing text:

Week 4 comes in strong: \$140 left over after the fixed bills. First breathing room in a month.

Same week, two facts are waiting:

- The catch-up bill (an old utility balance) has a **\$35 late fee that hits Friday.** (*Example.*)
- Your cushion, the money that absorbs the next shock, sits at **\$0.**

And one more thing: extra money that sits as cash in a shared place has a way of getting asked for.

Decide the split BEFORE payday. One line, four numbers:

\$_____ to the late-fee bill | \$_____ to the cushion | \$_____ planned treat | \$_____ family / other

The four numbers must add up to \$140. Add two at a time.

There is no split that does everything. Late fee ignored = the bill grows. Cushion at zero = the next shock lands on bare skin. No treat ever = the plan starts feeling like punishment, and plans that feel like punishment get abandoned. That is the real exercise: choose what each dollar is for, out loud to yourself, before the money arrives.

AFTER you finish. One version. Not the answer.

A common split: kill the late fee first (it is the only number that grows by itself), start the cushion with something small but real, keep a treat you chose on purpose, and make any family number a decision instead of a leak.

Activity instructions: Write your four numbers alone. Then pair talk: what did you protect first, and why? Numbers optional, reasons welcome.

Reflection prompt: My split, in one sentence, for my next good week: _____

Facilitator note (safety): The “gets asked for” line touches family pressure without naming anyone. If a learner starts describing a specific person taking their money, acknowledge and defer: that is Session 3’s page, and it deserves its own time.

Source-needed note: Late-fee amount illustrative.

Page 7: Before You Go (Session 2 close)

Learner-facing text:

One session, three ideas:

1. A predictable gap is a negotiable gap. The early ask is the cheapest bridge there is.
2. Plan to the floor, not the average. The floor is your truth number.
3. Good weeks are supplies. Split them on purpose, before the money lands.

My one reflection: My most likely gap or low week in the next two months is:

My action step (pick your track):

- **If you are still inside:** build your gap timeline for the first month out, in estimates. Release date, first likely bill, first likely paycheck.
- **If you are out:** find your real floor this week using the page 4 grid, and write your split rule for the next good week before it happens.

Activity instructions: Thirty seconds. Done beats perfect.

Facilitator note: none needed.

Source-needed note: none.

Workbook Draft: Session 3, The Conversations (v0.2)

Program: Budgeting & Emergency Savings (Correctional and Reentry) | Version: v0.2 (Session 3 content, post-audit) | Date: 2026-07-02 | Status: Needs Dalia review Supersedes v0.1 (kept as history). Applies all approved audit fixes. Spine focus: the early ask, obligation management, family pressure, least harm. All dollar amounts illustrative. Standalone-safe. Session shape: warm-up (5-10) → S04 (35) → breather (5) → S16 (30) → close (10).

Page 1: Welcome to Session 3, The Conversations

Learner-facing text:

Money pressure usually arrives as a person. Someone asking. Someone owed. Someone official.

Today is about the two hardest money conversations in the first months out: the one with family, and the one with an office. Neither has a perfect answer. Both go better when you have your sentence ready before you need it.

Ground rules, same as every session: worksheets are yours, you can pass on any share-out, some pages have no perfect answer (pick the least damage, make the first call early). **Still inside: use your best guesses. Out: use your real numbers. The pages work either way.**

Warm-up: the pressure pile (no names, 5 minutes).

1. Take one slip of paper. Everyone's slip looks the same.
2. Write ONE money pressure you know about, yours or anyone's. No names, no amounts. Three words is enough. ("Family asking." "Court fee." "Phone bill.") **Print in plain block letters.** Or take one of the pre-printed slips and fold that instead; nobody can tell the difference.
3. Fold it. All slips go in one pile, get shuffled, and are read out by the facilitator.
4. As a group, sort them into three piles: **urgent this week / heavy but not urgent / pressure from another person.**

That is the whole warm-up. Notice one thing: most rooms produce the same pressures. Whatever is on your slip, somebody else's slip is its cousin.

Activity instructions: above.

Facilitator note (safety): Enforce no-names strictly, including "my cousin" type names. Bring a small stack of pre-printed common-pressure slips (rent, family asking, court fee, phone, food, ride to work) so non-writers and anyone who prefers it can pick and fold one; that keeps every folded slip plausible for everyone. Shuffle before reading so no slip is traceable. Read slips in a flat, respectful voice. If a slip is too identifying, fold it back in without reading and say nothing.

Source-needed note: none.

Page 2: The Ask at Sunday Dinner (S04, the setup)

Learner-facing text:

Keisha's sister wrote to her every month inside. Put money on her books when nobody else did. Never missed.

Now Keisha is out, six weeks, working part time. She has \$260. Rent share is \$180, due Friday.

Sunday dinner. Her sister, quietly: "My lights are getting cut Wednesday. I need \$150. I would never ask if I had another way."

Every answer costs something real:

- **Yes** costs the rent, five days later.
- **No** costs something between two people who kept each other alive.
- **A partial** might still not keep the lights on, and still bends the rent.
- **An alternative** (help her call the utility, find the assistance program) costs time and might feel like a no.

There is no clean answer on this page. That is the point. The skill is choosing the least damage and saying it in a way you can live with.

Activity instructions: Read alone or aloud. Then build your sentence on the next page.

Facilitator note (safety): Some learners are living this exact scene. Before starting, say: "This is Keisha's page. Work it as Keisha. If it lands close to home, you can work it as yourself instead, on paper, privately." Role-play later is optional; passing is always allowed.

Source-needed note: Utility assistance programs exist in many places; specifics belong on the local-resource insert.

Page 3: Your Sentence (S04 worksheet)

Learner-facing text:

Pick the answer Keisha gives. Then **write the sentence only for the row you picked**. Not a speech. One sentence, maybe two. (If time is left, try a second row.)

			Keisha's sentence (write your picked row)
If the answer is...	What it protects	What it risks	
Yes, the full 150 <i>The relationship, today</i> now)	Some of both <i>Rent, Friday</i>	Maybe not enough <i>for either</i>	<i>Therent The relationship, tonight Partial(</i>

			Keisha's sentence (write your picked row)
If the answer is...	What it protects	What it risks	
Alternative (make the call together, find the program)	Both, if it works	Feeling like a no	

Two things that help a sentence hold:

- **A number and a date beat a maybe.** “I can do \$40 now and \$40 after Friday” is a real answer. “I will see what I can do” is a debt you have not counted yet.
- **“Not never, just not now”** is a real category. You are allowed to protect the rent AND the relationship.

Practice (optional, in pairs): one person reads the ask from page 2, the other answers with their sentence. Trade roles. If you would rather not, reading your sentence silently to yourself counts. Passing counts too.

AFTER you finish. One version. Not the answer.

People who have been on both sides of this table tend to say: the yes that breaks your rent helps nobody for long, because in two weeks there are two emergencies instead of one. The answers that age best are a partial with a date, or the alternative made together, said with respect, and kept.

Reflection prompt: Who is most likely to ask you? You do not have to write the name. Write the sentence you want ready.

Facilitator note (safety): Keep role-play script-based; if a pair drifts into real family history, bring it back to Keisha's page. Full-group fallback if role-play refuses to start: facilitator reads both parts aloud, room critiques the sentence, not the person.

Source-needed note: none.

Page 4: The Fee With Your Name On It (\$16, the setup)

Learner-facing text:

Take the five-minute breather before this page. Seriously. Two hard conversations deserve a breath between them.

Somewhere in the stack of things you owe, there may be one with an official name on it: a supervision fee, a court payment, a program obligation. The amount is different in every state, so this page leaves it blank: \$_____.

This week it is due, and phone and groceries do not fit beside it.

What this page will not do: it will not tell you which bill to pay first. It cannot. Rules are different in every state, and what is safe in one place is not safe in another. When the stakes are high, guessing alone can make the damage worse.

What this page will do: teach the three moves that are almost always better than silence.

1. **Ask early.** Before the due date beats after it, every time.
2. **Ask in writing, and keep a copy.** Offices run on paper. A dated question in writing enters the system; a hallway promise does not.
3. **Ask the right office.** Fee questions go to the office that charges the fee. Court-related questions can also go to free legal aid. Guessing offices wastes the week.

The most expensive move on this page is the one that feels safest: saying nothing and hoping.

Activity instructions: Read, then build your plan on the next page.

Facilitator note (boundary): This page draws questions like “can they violate me for not paying?” Do not answer, even if you think you know. The script: “That is exactly the question for the office or for legal aid, in writing. Let’s write it down as your ask.” Every state is different; the routing IS the lesson.

Source-needed note: Supervision/court fee amounts, waiver rules, and consequences are state-specific. No figures or rules are printed. Any future state insert requires current official sources and legal review. Free legal aid referral lines belong on the local-resource insert.

Page 5: The Early Conversation Plan (S16 worksheet)

Learner-facing text:

Fill in what you know. Blanks you cannot fill are your first questions.

My plan	Write it
The obligation with my name on it	
The right office to ask (name or best guess)	
My one question or request, in one sentence, written the way I would send it	
My record line: date I asked / who I asked / what I asked	___ / ___ / ___
If it is court-related: free legal aid is also an option. My note about that	

Some weeks nothing fits beside it. That happens, and it is not a failure of the plan. Then pick the least damage you can live with, and let the early ask be the first move, not the last.

This week's order, in my own hand: knowing an early ask is going out, write your least-damage order for the week. Yours, not ours. This workbook does not rank these bills, and no workbook should.

1. _____ 2. _____ 3. _____ 4.

One sentence that works in many offices: "I want to stay current. My money situation this month is [one honest line]. What options exist, and can I get the answer in writing?"

Activity instructions: Fill the plan. Pairs optional: practice saying the one sentence out loud once. Amounts stay private.

Reflection prompt: What has kept the ask from happening before now: not knowing the office, not having the words, or the fear of asking? Circle one, privately.

Facilitator note (boundary): If a learner discloses being behind on a court obligation, do not assess their risk; acknowledge, and point at the page: "That is what the plan on this page is for. Office, writing, copy." If they need more, the referral is legal aid, not the classroom.

Source-needed note: covered on page 4.

Page 6: Before You Go (Session 3 close)

Learner-facing text:

One session, three ideas:

1. Money pressure usually arrives as a person. Have your sentence ready before you need it.
2. A number and a date beat a maybe, with family and with offices.
3. Silence is the most expensive option on the official stack. Ask early, in writing, at the right office, and keep the copy.

My one reflection: The conversation I have been putting off is with: (person / office, no names needed) and my first sentence will be: _____

My action step (pick your track):

- **If you are still inside:** write both sentences now, the family one and the office one, and keep them with your release papers. Walking out with words ready is walking out stronger.
- **If you are out:** send or say ONE of the two sentences this week. The heavier one can wait until next week. One is enough.

Activity instructions: Thirty seconds. Done beats perfect.

Facilitator note (safety): End this session gently; it is the heaviest one. A closing line that works: "Two hard pages in one day is real work. That was the hardest session in this course. It gets more practical from here."

Source-needed note: none.

Workbook Draft: Session 4, Shocks, Traps, and the Plan (v0.3)

Program: Budgeting & Emergency Savings (Correctional and Reentry) | Version: v0.3 (Session 4 content; F-1 and F-2 claim fixes applied) | Date: 2026-07-03 | Status: Needs Dalia review (two flagged precision adjustments, see end matter) Supersedes v0.2 (kept as history). ONLY changes: the two Dalia-approved claim fixes (ledger F-1, F-2) in Page 2. All other pages verbatim from the approved v0.2. Session shape: S07 opener (20) → S19 Part A (25) + Part B side-beat (5, if time) → S20 protected closer (25) → module close (15). S20's time is protected; if the session runs long, cut the side-beat, never the closer.

Page 1: Welcome to Session 4 + The Car That Gets You to Work (S07, 20-minute group opener)

Learner-facing text:

Earlier sessions in one line (or if this is your first class, here is the whole course so far): when money is short, the order you pay in is the decision, plan to your worst week not your average one, and have your hard-conversation sentence ready before you need it.

Ground rules, same as every session: worksheets are yours, passing on share-outs is allowed, some pages have no perfect answer. **Still inside: use your best guesses. Out: use your real numbers. The pages work either way.**

Today: what to do when the shock actually lands, and how to keep the fix from costing more than the problem.

Darius's Tuesday. The alternator dies. The shop says \$280. His job is 40 minutes away, next shift in two days. He also has a curfew condition, so late travel is not an option. (*Amounts are examples.*)

Four ways out are on the table:

- **A. Title loan** against the car. Fast money today.
- **B. Ask the new boss for an advance.** He has been there five weeks.
- **C. Mechanic payment plan.** Half now, half in two weeks, if the shop agrees.
- **D. The bus.** Two transfers, adds three hours a day, and the late shift gets home after curfew.

As a group, answer these three, one option at a time:

1. What does this option risk that is bigger than \$280?
2. What would you need to ask, and of whom, before choosing it?
3. Which option risks the thing that earns the money?

Activity instructions: Group discussion, 20 minutes, facilitator keeps the three questions moving. No worksheet; this one is spoken.

Facilitator note (clarity): Do not let the room settle on one “right” option. A puts the car itself on the table, B costs new-job optics, C depends on the shop, D collides

with the curfew. The lesson is the three questions, not the winner.

Facilitator note (boundary): If curfew rules come up (“could he get permission for late travel?”), route it: conditions vary; the question goes to the supervising officer, early and in writing, same as Session 3.

Source-needed note: Title-loan mechanics: see claims ledger CL-10 (CFPB, Single-Payment Vehicle Title Lending, May 2016; qualitative use here).

Page 2: Tonight or Twelve Months (S19 Part A, the menu)

Learner-facing text:

Same problem, different day: you need \$250, this week. Four offers are on the table. Every one of them works tonight. They do not cost the same over twelve months.

Rank them 1 to 4 before anything is revealed. Judge each on two things: **what it costs in total**, and **what it risks that earns your money**.

Offer	What it gives tonight	What is in the fine print	My rank (1 = least damage)
Payday loan	\$250 cash	Due in full from the next check, plus fees	
Cash-advance “free” app	\$250 to your card	Tips and instant-transfer fees add per use; the amount comes out of the next check	
Pawn your work tools	\$250 today	If you do not redeem it by the deadline, the shop can keep the tools; exact rules vary	
Ask the employer for an advance / call the biller and ask for time	\$250, or the bill moves	It is a hard conversation, and it might be a no	

Activity instructions: Rank alone first. Then the group compares rankings and argues it out. The facilitator opens the cost picture only after the argument.

AFTER you rank. The cost picture.

The payday route can cost much more than the first fee suggests. A 2014 CFPB study found that more than four out of five payday loans are rolled over or followed by

another loan within two weeks, and that three out of five payday loans go to borrowers who pay more in fees than they borrowed. When the next check is already short, restarting the cycle becomes the danger.

The app costs less per use but quietly pre-spends every check. The pawn costs the least in fees and risks the most. A pawn or title option may put the thing you need for work at risk. The exact rules depend on the product and state. The point here is not legal strategy. The point is to ask: does this option put the thing that earns your money in danger?

The ask costs no fees, but it is not free: it can cost pride, awkwardness at a new job, or a no. It still usually risks the least of what earns your money, which is exactly why it is the one nobody wants to pick. Notice the pattern from the rest of this course: the cheapest money keeps being a sentence you say early.

Reflection prompt: Which offer would you actually have taken six months ago? What made it feel like the only one?

Facilitator note (boundary): This page compares costs; it does not recommend products or promise an employer will say yes. Keep it on the two questions: total cost, and risk to the earner. Fee mechanics live in the Banking & Credit program; do not re-teach them here.

Source-needed note: Sourced per claims ledger v0.2: payday mechanics CL-07 (CFPB Ask CFPB pages, 2024); reborrowing finding CL-11 (CFPB Data Point: Payday Lending, March 2014); advance apps CL-08 (CFPB Data Spotlight, July 2024); pawn CL-09; title CL-10. Refresh windows in the ledger.

Page 3: The One That Was Never Real (S19 Part B, 5-minute side-beat)

Learner-facing text:

One more offer arrives while you are deciding. A text, from a number you do not know:

“CONGRATS! You are PRE-APPROVED for \$500. No credit check. No ID needed. Click the link, funds tonight!!”

One question, thirty seconds, before reading on: **what tells you this one is not even a real offer?**

Write your answer: _____

AFTER you write. Three tells, and you likely found at least one: it arrived without being asked for; it needs nothing from you (no credit check, no ID) which means it is not lending, it is fishing; and it manufactures speed (tonight, click now) because pressure is the product. Real costs can be compared, like the menu on the last page. Fake offers cannot; they only need one click.

Scams get their own full program in this academy. For today, keep the one move that beats most of them: **when money is tight and something arrives fast and easy, slow down on purpose.**

Activity instructions: Individual, then one minute of group tells.

Reflection prompt: built in above.

Facilitator note (clarity): If the session is running long, cut this page entirely; never cut the next one. The closer's 25 minutes are protected.

Source-needed note: none (no factual claims).

Page 4: The Zero-Dollar Emergency Plan (\$20, protected 25-minute closer)

Learner-facing text:

Here is the trap inside the phrase “emergency fund”: it makes people with \$0 think they have no move. Wrong. A plan is a move. This page builds an emergency plan that costs nothing to make and is worth the most on your worst day.

Fill in the boxes, in order. Blanks are allowed; a blank you know about is better than a surprise.

In order	My plan
1. Who I call or tell FIRST when a money shock hits (a person, or a community help line if there is no person)	
2. What I can ask for more time on (the bill, and the office or person to ask)	
3. What I can skip or shrink for two weeks without losing housing, food, legality, or work	
4. What I could sell, if anything (optional line; skip it freely)	
5. What I will NOT do, no matter how fast it sounds (your losers list from the menu page)	

Now copy the five lines, small, onto the wallet card below. Cut or tear it out. This card is the cushion before the cushion: it exists so that on the bad day, the thinking is already done.

```
+-----+
| MY SHOCK PLAN |
| 1. First call: _____ |
```

2. Ask for time:	_____
3. Skip/shrink:	_____
4. (optional):	_____
5. Never:	_____

+-----+

Activity instructions: Individual, quiet, 25 minutes protected. This is the take-home of the whole course; it does not get rushed.

Reflection prompt: Read your card once. Which line was hardest to fill? That line is your homework.

Facilitator note (safety): Line 4 is optional and stays optional; never press anyone on what they own. If a learner has no first-call person, the community help line answer is a full answer, not a lesser one. (A general community-resource line also appears in the Banking & Credit take-homes; local numbers belong on the local-resource insert.)

Source-needed note: Community help line references stay generic; local numbers go on the per-facility insert.

Page 5: Before You Go (module close)

Learner-facing text:

First, a 60-second sort. Three things happen the same week. Mark each one: **E** = emergency now, **C** = coming anyway (should be planned, not treated as a surprise), or **P** = pressure wearing an emergency costume.

- ___ The car that gets you to work will not start
- ___ A winter coat for December, and it is October
- ___ Your cousin wants \$100 tonight for something he will not explain, and keeps calling

(Most people land on E, C, P, in that order. The argument for other answers is worth one minute of group talk, no more.)

Now write yours. My emergency, in one line: an emergency is _____
(your definition; it guards your money from things that are loud but not emergencies).

Four sessions, one skill. When money is short:

1. **Slow the damage.** The order is the decision; pay the plan, not the pressure.
2. **Protect the next step.** The floor, the earner, the thing that makes next week possible.
3. **Ask early.** With family, with offices, with billers. A number and a date beat a maybe. In writing when it is official.
4. **Keep one option open.** A backup move, a small cushion, a wallet card. One open option is the difference between a bad week and a spiral.

My action steps:

- **If you are still inside:** your shock-plan card, your emergency definition, and your two sentences (family, office) go with your release papers. That is the whole assignment.
- **If you are out, this week:** put the wallet card where your money is. Do one triage action (sort the real bill stack once). Set the first cushion rung, even if it is \$0 with a date. Say one early-ask sentence.

Activity instructions: Sort (1 minute), definition line, circle your track. Three minutes total; the sort borrows from the wrap time, never from S20.

Facilitator note (clarity): If the optional capstone session is running, tell the room what it is (plan assembly + first paycheck session) and when. If not, this page is the ending; land it with respect.

Source-needed note: none.

Optional Capstone: The First 30 Days (v0.2)

Program: Budgeting & Emergency Savings (Correctional and Reentry) | Version: v0.2 (post-audit) | Date: 2026-07-03 | Status: Needs Dalia review **Pilot label (Dalia decision): Optional add-on, not required for pilot completion.** Ships in pilot materials; a facility may run 4 sessions only and the pilot is complete. Supersedes v0.1 (kept as history). Applies all approved audit fixes and owner decisions; change list in end matter. Purpose: take the learner from “I learned pieces” to “I can use this in the first 30 days.” Review only: no new concepts. 60-90 minutes. All dollar amounts illustrative; worksheets private; no public dollar amounts; no legal or product advice.

Three delivery modes, one set of pages: - **Mode A:** optional fifth session (same facilitator, same room) - **Mode B:** reentry workshop review, **for people who completed the four sessions, whenever that was.** It is not an introduction; a group that never took the course gets Session 1, not the capstone. - **Mode C:** partner-led post-release session (run by the trusted reentry partner using this run sheet)

Review cards (print one set per learner; four cards, one half-page; these carry the course for anyone who missed sessions)

CARD 1, THE ORDER: When money is short, the order is the decision. Protect housed, fed, legal, and working first. Whatever you skip, name its backup.

CARD 2, THE FLOOR: Plan to your smallest week, not your average week. Any plan that needs more than the floor is a hope, not a plan. Good weeks are supplies, not raises.

CARD 3, THE EARLY ASK: Some weeks have no good option. Pick the least damage, and make the first call early. A number and a date beat a maybe. In writing when it is official; keep the copy.

CARD 4, THE NEVER-DO LIST: Fast money prices your bad week. Before taking any fast-money offer, ask two questions: what does it cost in total, and does it put the thing that earns your money in danger? When something arrives fast and easy, slow down on purpose.

Learner pages

Page 1: Welcome back (or welcome)

Learner-facing text:

This session is one thing: turning the course into your first 30 days.

If you took the four sessions, this is your assembly hour. If you did not, the four cards on your table carry the core: the order, the floor, the early ask, and the never-do list. Read them once; the pages will do the rest.

Ground rules, same as always: your worksheets are yours, nobody collects them, you can pass on any share-out, and we never say dollar amounts out loud in this room. Still inside: use best guesses. Out: use your real numbers.

Facilitator note (clarity): Read the four cards aloud for the room regardless of who attended what. Two minutes. That is the whole recap; do not re-teach.

Page 2: My five, refreshed

Learner-facing text:

Five things from the course belong to you. Refresh each one, current as of today. Blanks are honest answers; a blank you know about is a to-do, not a failure.

Mine	Write or update it
My floor (the leftover in my smallest week; guess if needed)	\$_____ (private)
My early-ask sentence (the one I would actually say, to family or an office)	
My shock plan (wallet card: still true? update lines that changed)	checked ☐ updated ☐ need a new card ☐
My fast-money warning sign (the personal tell that I am about to grab expensive money; e.g. "it is 9 pm and I am scared")	
My one line from the local resource sheet (the one I would realistically call first; circle it on the sheet)	

Activity instructions: Silent work, 15 minutes. Pairs optional afterward: share the warning sign or the sentence if you want to; never the numbers.

Facilitator note (safety): The warning-sign line is S19's slow-down move made personal, not a new concept. If someone cannot name one, offer the room's common ones aloud: late at night, right after bad news, when someone is waiting on an answer.

Source-needed note: Local resource sheet must be on the table for this page; Mode C uses the partner's own verified copy.

Page 3: The First 30 Days money map

Learner-facing text:

One page, four weeks. This is the course in one map. Estimates are fine; the map is what survives contact with the month.

	Money in (guess or real)	What gets protected first	My backup move this week	One ask-early item (who, by when)
Week 1	\$ _____			
Week 2	\$ _____			
Week 3	\$ _____			
Week 4	\$ _____			

Then two lines below the map:

****My smallest week above is: Week ____.**** That is the week the plan must survive. (That is your floor talking.)

If a shock lands anywhere in the 30 days: my shock plan card is the answer, starting with the first call.

Activity instructions: 25 minutes, silent, pencil. The facilitator does not check maps; the map is yours. If you finish early, stress-test it: pick your smallest week and ask what moves, what must not move.

Facilitator note (clarity): For pre-release learners the whole map is estimates keyed to their release month; say that plainly. For Mode C groups, real numbers, privately.

Page 4: One next step, and out

Learner-facing text:

Privacy-safe reflection (for you, not the room): the piece of this course I have actually used, or will use first, is: _____

My one next step (circle exactly one, do it within a week):

- Make the one resource-sheet call I circled
- Say or send my early-ask sentence
- Put the shock-plan card where my money is
- Walk my real numbers through the 30-day map once
- Set my first cushion amount, even if it is \$0 with a date

That is the whole assignment. One step. Done beats perfect.

Facilitator note: Close with respect; this may be the last time this group is in a room together. No go-around share-out; the reflection stays on the page.

Facilitator run sheet

Timing, 90-minute version: cards + welcome 10 / Page 2 “my five” 20 / Page 3 map 30 / stress-test + optional pair talk 15 / Page 4 close 15. **Timing, 60-minute**

version: cards + welcome 5 / Page 2 15 / Page 3 25 / Page 4 15. Cut the pair talk and stress-test, never the map or the close.

Materials: capstone pages, one four-card review set per learner, pencils, the site's verified local resource sheet (launch-gate rules apply), learners' wallet cards if they have them (blank cards available for those who do not). Mode C adds: the two-sided scripts card.

Mode notes: - **Mode A (fifth session):** run as printed. The default remains: the post-assessment happens at the end of Session 4. If a site moves the post-assessment to this sitting instead, it comes FIRST, before any review (no-leakage logic), **and the sitting is scheduled at 105 minutes; never compress the capstone to fit the assessment.** - **Mode B (workshop review):** for completers of the four sessions only (see the mode definition above). The cards do the recap; expect wider variance in what people remember; Page 2 carries the session. - **Mode C (partner-led):** the trusted reentry partner runs it with this sheet. Same privacy rules as everything else: nothing collected, no amounts aloud, worksheets stay with learners. **Attendance is not reported to anyone. Coming, not coming, and leaving early carry no consequence and generate no record.** The partner does not need facilitator training for this session, but reads the facilitator guide's principles page (section 2) first, **and keeps the two-sided scripts card on the table:** if a learner asks a legal, benefits, or case question, the partner routes it with the card's words, the right office, in writing, or legal aid. No assessment activity happens in Mode C.

Boundaries (unchanged from the course): no legal, financial, tax, or credit-repair advice; no product recommendations; no public dollar amounts; pass option always; the resource sheet is the routing answer.

What this session is not: not a new module, not a data-collection event, not a graduation ceremony with speeches. It is one hour that turns four sessions into thirty days.
